ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Mixed conditionals

Mixed conditionals are not random tense combinations. They are timelines: first locate the unreal cause, then locate its imagined result.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Relate cause and result when they belong to different time frames.

Connect an unreal cause in one time frame with its consequence in another: a past decision shaping the present, or a present condition changing the past.

MODEL

If I had taken that job, I would live in London now.

if + past perfect -> would + base verb | if + past simple -> would have + past participle

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Distinguish past causes with present results.

OUTCOME 2

02

Build present conditions with past results.

OUTCOME 3

03

Choose each verb form from the real timeline rather than from a memorised label.

Build meaning before form

Connect an unreal cause in one time frame with its consequence in another: a past decision shaping the present, or a present condition changing the past.

When a past decision changes the present

This pattern imagines a different past and follows its consequence into the present. If I had studied medicine, I would be a doctor now means that the study choice did not happen and the present identity is different.

The past perfect marks the closed opportunity. Would + base verb describes the present consequence that would still be true now.

If she had accepted the offer,	she would work in Berlin now.
If we had left earlier,	we would be there by now.

When a present state explains a past result

A stable characteristic can be treated as the reason a past event turned out differently. If I were more organised, I would not have missed the deadline links a present trait to a completed past mistake.

The present condition is grammatically remote, so formal English often uses were for every person. The result needs would have + past participle because the opportunity has already passed.

Reality	Counterfactual
I am not organised; I missed it.	If I were organised, I would not have missed it.
He is shy; he did not speak.	If he were less shy, he would have spoken.

A timeline test that prevents errors

Do not begin with the label “mixed conditional.” Ask two concrete questions: when does the cause belong, and when does the result belong? Those answers determine the two verb phrases.

Time markers such as now, today, yesterday and last year make the contrast visible, but the meaning can establish the timeline even when no marker appears.

Meaning before form

A correct form must also express a plausible cause-and-effect relationship. If the two clauses do not logically influence one another, the sentence may be grammatical but communicatively weak.

Read the finished sentence as a contrast between reality and imagination: what actually happened, and what would be different?

Reason through the pattern

Two crossing arrows show the cause on one timeline and the result on another. Read from the if-clause to the consequence, then compare both with reality.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08
if	past perfect	would	base verb	if	past simple	would have	past participle

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

STEP 3

Decision 3

Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Timeline	If-clause	Result
past -> present	if + had + participle	would + base verb + now
present -> past	if + past simple	would have + participle
past -> past	if + past perfect	would have + participle

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

had taken the job	would live there now
were more careful	would not have broken it
had left earlier	would be here now

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Copying the same tense into both clauses without checking time.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Putting would inside the if-clause.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Omitting have from an unreal past result.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

If I had studied architecture, I ___ buildings now.

OPTIONS would design · would have designed · designed · will design

A2 · CONTEXT 2

If Marta were more organised, she ___ the deadline yesterday.

OPTIONS would not have missed · would not miss · had not missed · will not miss

A3 · CONTEXT 3

If they had not moved abroad, we ___ them every weekend.

OPTIONS would see · would have seen · saw · had seen

A4 · CONTEXT 4

If he were more confident, he ___ for the promotion last month.

OPTIONS would have applied · would apply · had applied · applied

A5 · CONTEXT 5

If we had booked earlier, we ___ in a better hotel now.

OPTIONS would be staying · would have stayed · stay · had stayed

A6 · CONTEXT 6

If I were not allergic to nuts, I ___ that cake at the party.

OPTIONS would have tried · would try · had tried · will have tried

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

If Leo _____ the training last year, he _____ the team now.

OPTIONS Gap 1: had completed / completed / would complete · Gap 2: would lead / would have led / led

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

If I _____ less impulsive, I _____ that message last night.

OPTIONS Gap 1: were / had been / would be · Gap 2: would not have sent / would not send / had not sent

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

If she _____ English as a child, she _____ for an interpreter today.

OPTIONS Gap 1: had learned / learned / would learn · Gap 2: would not need / would not have needed / did not need

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

03 · PRACTICE STAGE

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

If I _____ the scholarship ten years ago, I _____ in Canada now. If I _____ so afraid of change, I _____ the opportunity. My career _____ very different today if I _____ that decision.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

accepted · had accepted · had made · had not been · had taken · lived · made · was · were not · would accept · would be · would be living · would have been · would have lived · would have taken · would make · would not be · would take

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

If we _____ (invest) earlier, the company would be stronger now. If I _____ (be) more patient, I would not have interrupted her. He would speak French today if he _____ (grow up) in Paris. If Sara were less cautious, she _____ (accept) the offer yesterday. We would not be lost now if you _____ (download) the map.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Combine: I did not learn to code. I do not work in tech now.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Combine: I am impatient. I argued with the client yesterday.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Correct: If she would have moved, she lived in Madrid now.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Write an original Mixed conditionals response for context 4. Include had, would.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Mixed conditionals response for context 1. Include had, would.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Mixed conditionals response for context 2. Include had invested, would be.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Mixed conditionals response for context 3. Include would.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: cause.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: result.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: past perfect.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: would have.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

would design

Use “would design”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

A2

would not have missed

Use “would not have missed”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

A3

would see

Use “would see”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

A4

would have applied

Use “would have applied”. Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

A5

would be staying

Use “would be staying”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

A6

would have tried

Use “would have tried”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

had completed / would lead

Use “had completed”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state? Use “would lead”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

B2

were / would not have sent

Use “were”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment? Use “would not have sent”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

B3

had learned / would not need

Use “had learned”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition. Use “would not need”. Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

had accepted

Use “had accepted”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

C2

would be living

Use “would be living”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

C3

were not

Use “were not”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

C4

would have taken

Use “would have taken”. Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

C5

would be

Use “would be”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

C6

had made

Use “had made”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

had invested

Use “had invested”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

D2

were

Use “were”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

D3

had grown up

Use “had grown up”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

D4

would have accepted

Use “would have accepted”. Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

D5

had downloaded

Use “had downloaded”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

If I had learned to code, I would work in tech now.

Use “If I had learned to code, I would work in tech now.”. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

E2

If I were more patient, I would not have argued with the client yesterday.

Use “If I were more patient, I would not have argued with the client yesterday.”. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

E3

If she had moved, she would live in Madrid now.

Use “If she had moved, she would live in Madrid now.”. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

E4

If I had chosen differently, my life would be different now.

Use “If I had chosen differently, my life would be different now.”. Use would have + past participle for an unreal past result.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

If I had moved abroad, I would speak another language now. If I were braver, I would have applied.

The model combines accurate Mixed conditionals with a clear purpose. Locate the cause first: is it a past event or a present state?

F2

If the company had invested in training, staff turnover would be lower now.

The model combines accurate Mixed conditionals with a clear purpose. Locate the consequence: does it describe now or a completed past moment?

F3

If we had planned better, we would be on schedule. If the team were more flexible, it would have adapted faster.

The model combines accurate Mixed conditionals with a clear purpose. Use the past perfect for an unreal past condition.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____